



YOU ARE **30 WEEKS AND 3 DAYS**

67 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

It can come as quite a surprise to see that your baby will be increasingly making all sorts of expressions. Here the baby had their mouth turned down but the next minute will be yawning, grimacing, or peacefully sleeping.

“Natural birth has many advocates, but the best birth is one that delivers your baby safely with minimum trauma for both of you.”

Giving birth naturally is for some reason perceived as the “best” way, and to do otherwise means that you somehow “failed.” This pressure can cause women to feel guilty or even depressed if they needed pain relief or a Cesarean section, for example.

Pain is experienced differently for everyone and there is no right or wrong way to manage the pain of labor. Be sure you understand all your options for pain management, and be open-minded about what the best option is for you in that moment. Pain is subjective—no one else can feel your pain; if it is too much for you, then ask for help. Your options (see [Drugs for pain relief](#)) will be explained to you by the doctor.

Childbirth is hard work, but the experience should not be so painful that it scars you. Being pain-free may mean that you have a more enjoyable, even empowering, labor experience. If you do decide you want pain relief, an epidural is the most common option—more than half of women having a baby in a hospital receive one.

ASK A PANEL

I want a natural birth, but everyone says I’ll change my mind once I’m in labor. Are they right?

Mom: Nothing can prepare you for the pain of labor, and I found my carefully laid plans were unrealistic and impractical when the pain kicked in. No matter how well prepared you are, you may change your mind during labor, and it’s worth being prepared for that. I did feel a bit disappointed that I couldn’t manage without pain relief. It helps if you focus on what’s important—delivering a healthy baby. If you achieve this aim, you’ve succeeded, no matter what happens along the way. I would say to stick it out for as long as you can, but you’ll be doing yourself and your baby no favors if you both become exhausted and distressed.

Doctor: Many women are shocked by the intensity of the birth experience, and soon forget about their idealistic birth plan. It’s better for all involved that you allow for contingency plans during labor, and keep an open mind. [Pain relief](#) and interventions are designed to make the experience